The eArchiving reference curriculum for digital preservation

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The eArchiving Initiative[1] has been tasked with developing a reference for academic curricula for digital preservation, mainly addressed to the master level. The eArchiving Reference Curriculum[2] therefore covers keys aspects for that purpose, including data integrity, security, and long-term accessibility, intending to be a guide mainly for academics preparing specific programs, but also relevant to guide students creating an understanding of the domain. The objective is to prepare students for professional roles of “eArchivists” or of digital preservation specialists, across public or private sectors. The curriculum seeks to foster critical engagement with advanced technologies and methodologies in the field of eArchiving, including awareness of regulations and laws, with a focus in Europe. Emphasis is placed on developing the competencies necessary to conceptualize, implement, assess, and critically reflect on discipline-specific challenges and innovations.

Through a comprehensive scoping exercise aimed at assessing the current availability of eArchiving-related courses within the European higher education sector, a dataset was developed based on a defined search methodology.[3] This methodology encompassed a discovery for two primary categories: (1) higher education courses explicitly incorporating "digital preservation" in their titles or syllabi, thereby demonstrating a direct engagement with the domain of eArchiving, or (2) courses that, while not explicitly referencing "digital preservation," address related topics, indicating their potential relevance to the eArchiving domain or body of knowledge.

Led by INESC-ID, this initiative contributed significantly to the enhancement of the eArchiving Academic Curriculum through an analysis of existing course offerings. As a result, the exercise facilitated the identification of emerging trends and existing gaps in digital preservation education within higher education. These findings offer critical insights for refining eArchiving guidelines, ensuring their comprehensiveness and relevance.[4] Consequently, the dataset produced from this analysis will serve as a pivotal resource for elevating educational standards in digital preservation and promoting the broader dissemination of eArchiving knowledge across academic institutions.

Through the analytical framework established by the scoping exercise, including its methodologies and corresponding outcomes, a modular structure has been implemented to accommodate the diverse academic frameworks across Europe. This modular approach enables the adoption of the curriculum in its entirety or selectively integrate specific modules that align with a particular objective. An initial proposal has been made for a minimum of six core (mandatory) modules (M1–6). These are M1. ‘An introduction to eArchiving’; M2.‘eArchiving standards and specifications’; M3. eArchiving software tools; M4. ‘eArchiving data and documents’; M5. ‘Legal and Regulatory Compliance’; M6. ‘Independent project’.[5]

In conclusion, disseminating information about eArchiving, particularly the eArchiving Academic Curriculum, within the European academic community can significantly raise awareness and foster the integration of these essential guidelines into higher education programs. By promoting a curriculum that is informed by real input from the eArchiving community, it not only supports the academic development of students but also contributes to the growth and enhancement of the broader eArchiving community. The European-focused course presents a significant opportunity to advance the field by aligning academic education with the evolving needs and challenges of the community, ultimately benefiting both students and professionals within the discipline, as highlighted in the eArchiving – Reference Curriculum report by the eArchiving Initiative.

Notes

1. eArchiving Initiative | Shaping Europe’s Digital Future’, 25 November 2024, https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/activities/earchiving
2. eArchiving - Training and Curriculum | Shaping Europe’s Digital Future’, 25 November 2024, https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/activities/earchiving-training
3. The data set may be seen in the following URL: https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1J5FCB-Z64ILHvM9lG1IQr6ArPrVVQaKHjTCesKh8rZbg
4. In the data set is possible to understand the following results: at least 213 post-graduate courses are being taught in Europe that include some

element of digital preservation or eArchiving content; These courses are being provided by 89 institutions in 27 countries (The countries with the highest level of provision are France (29 courses), Germany (20 courses), Italy (20 courses) and the UK (22 courses); In the majority of cases, the courses are provided in English (104), with French language used in 35 courses, German in 31 and Italian in 16; In most of these 213 courses, digital preservation and eArchiving comprise a small component of the course, such as a module. Very few courses focus exclusively on eArchiving or digital preservation.

5. For a more detailed understanding of each module, including their definitions and primary objectives, please refer to the E-ARK Foundation website, specifically the 'Reference Curriculum' page, available via the following link: «Curriculum – E-ARK Foundation». Acedido 3 de dezembro de 2024. https://www.e-ark-foundation.eu/curriculum/ .

Bibliography

European Commission (2024): “eArchiving Initiative | Shaping Europe’s Digital Future”, https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/activities/earchiving [30.04.2025]

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